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Jimmy Lewis

Bassist Jimmy Lewis was born in Nashville in 1918. He first played ukulele in bands, later picking up the bass to anchor some inspired jazz rhythm sections, including the Count Basie small group in the early 1950s. Jimmy has worked with Billie Holiday, Horace Silver and the Modern Jazz Quartet. His experience includes work in rhythm & blues as well, and he can be heard on albums with King Curtis, Ivory Joe Hunter and numerous soul organists. His musical contribution to the Broadway hit "Hair" helped ensure its wide success and he was a featured figure in the documentary "Count Basie, Swingin' the Blues."

Jimmy was interviewed in New York City by Monk Rowe on November 16, 1995. Mary Kopcza also participated in part of the interview.

MR: We are here today in New York filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. My name is Monk Rowe and it's a great pleasure to have bassist Jimmy Lewis with us. Welcome. You're a Kansas City native?

JL: No, Nashville, Tennessee.

MR: Nashville. What was music like in Nashville when you grew up?

JL: Well there was a lot of jazz around the schools you know, and they had some nice bands — Fisk University, a big band you know? And I started, I was around most of the good musicians that came, and so I met a guy that was going to Fisk. He was Professor Snead. And he played all the string instruments. He started me out on the ukulele. I started out on the ukulele. I was about ten years old. And I got to be pretty famous in and around town.

MR: On the ukulele.

JL: And so I played in the high school, you know these little concerts and things. And then one day I was sitting on my front porch playing the ukulele and a guy came by in a car and stopped in the front of the house, and says — and I wondered why is this guy out here? And he just stood there and I kept playing. So finally he called me to come over to his car. I came over and got in the car with him and he says, "how long you been playing?" So I guess I'd been playing about two years. So he said, "well I got somebody I want you to meet." And so he took me to a guy named Bill Regis. He was a band leader, but he played guitar. So I met Bill, and Bill asked me to play a few tunes. I played a tune on the ukulele and he hired me on the spot. You know it was such a surprise you know. I said well now what am I going to do with a big band playing the ukulele? So Bill said, "well I'll play the background on the guitar and you take all the solos on the ukulele." I was soloing on the ukulele like it was a guitar. So we went into a place called the Top Hat

Lounge, and went in there for two weeks. And the man liked it so well he kept us for a year. One straight year. Seven days a week.

MR: For a whole year.

JL: On ukulele. At the end of the year he says, "everybody keeps asking about a bass fiddle." He said, "You don't have one of these." So I said uh oh, they're going to get rid of me and get a bass. So what I did, I went down the next day to a place and got me a bass. I brought it home, didn't know anything about it. Had it tuned, had a man in the store tune it up, and the first string, the G string, I could play everything on the G string. It's one string, right here. And so I got my book, I think one of these Bob Haggart books. And I stayed in that book for about six months. And I came out playing better than anybody in the town. I taught myself.

MR: Well I think your ukulele playing must have helped.

JL: Yeah, it was for tone you know, and sound, chords and all that. So I went back, took the bass to the club that night, and the guy was surprised to see me walk in with a bass you know. I took my ukulele too in case it didn't work out. So I played, you know he called the tunes and I played everything by ear, everything in tune and everything, but on one string. At that time you used to use the gut strings on the bass. And so I'd wear out a string a week. Every week I had to get a new G string. The other strings —

MR: They were just sitting there.

JL: Yeah. So after a while I stayed in that book and I learned to play that bass pretty good, positions and chords and all these things, harmonics and everything. So then somebody called me for a record date. Now I never made a record date. I think it was Bullet Records. And so we took, I went down there and — no music written. So I played all the tunes they had and so they paid me. I get home, the phone rings and they call me again. Same company. I went back, did some more, and then I got back home and the guy called me and said, "how would you to work in the club with me?" I said, "Well I just finished a club," you know the one I was telling you about. He said, "well this club is different because I play shows." Well I had learned the bass well enough to do that then. So I went in the place called Zanzibar. It was a big club. You know with seats all around up here and down here a big dance floor and a bandstand. So I went in that place and I formed a little trio called the Blue Sky Trio. So I went in there and we played the first set, the people were dancing you know and everything. And they wanted to know about the bass. "Where'd he get the bass player?" I did everything wrong. My strings was too high, I had tape all over my fingers, but it had a big sound. You know I could play.

MR: You must have been working awful hard at it, right?

JL: Yeah. So after we stayed there for a while the man said, "look, next week we're going to have a show every night, seven nights." And he said, "why don't you, just your trio

play." And he said, "we're going to have maybe six acts to play for." They had dancers, singers, comedians, everything, you know all kinds of guys dancing on skates on top of vibes and all of that. So we had to play this music. So the group I had, we had formed a style that sounded like a big band because we listened to Basie and the Duke and we'd take and play those riffs and all of that. So the trio would play the same way. So the people liked what we did and the place started getting crowded, because like I say every night — seven nights we came in. So I stayed there I think about three years. And then I left and went to another club right down the street, called the Herod Club, upstairs, so we got a night club and we played a few tunes just with the trio then we added a horn you know. We added a horn and one night a guy came in and says, a guy came in with his guitar in his arm, old raincoat you know, and hat all crumpled up. He says, "Could I sit in with you guys?" So we looked the guy and I said, "I don't know." One of the guys said, "You think you can play?" I said, "All right, come up." He got up and he tuned up his guitar all open strings you know, and so he said, "What do you want to play?" So we started calling jazz tunes like "How High the Moon" and stuff like that. He said, "Okay." And he played, and the guy played so well that he got through it. I said, "What's your name?" He said, "Bill Jennings." You know Bill used to play with Dogett?

MR: Yeah.

JL: Yeah, and left handed too, with the guitar upside down playing. So after Bill, we left the stand, and I said I got to get myself together. I said because we're going to have some good people coming in here. So then one night a guy named Jim Mahenza came in and he heard me play. So he says, "how would you like to go to Louisville, Kentucky and play in a club with me there?" I said, "I don't know." He said, "well it would be a quartet — horn, bass, piano and drums." I said, "okay, I'll give it a try." I went in this club and we played for about two weeks. About three days before it was time for us to close the engagement, Basie and his group walked in. He stopped at the door back there and he listened, and I was walking behind Jim Mahenza playing bass, you know down the aisles we'd go. So he asked his manager to come over and talk to me and he wanted me to join his band you know. So I didn't know what to do then. I figured big time. But Nat King Cole had called me. He wanted me to take Joe Comfort's place. Because Joe was leaving. So he sent an admirer to come join the band. And let's see who else? Johnny Johanna? He was a singer. He used to come to my house and he'd sit down and write songs. And so he had sent and admired and to join his band. Now here comes Basie. So I told him I got to go back to Nashville first, and I'll let you know later. As soon as I get back in Nashville, two days later he called me on the phone, Basie did, from Chicago. He says, "I sent you a ticket, you've got a ticket on the way. Meet me in Chicago." Now I'm stumped and I said I don't know, I owe all these guys money. So I talked to a few of the guys in

the clubs and they said, "well what you do, go with Basie, you'll get more experience." They said, "we're going to miss you but I think it'd be a good deal for you." So I went with Basie. I met him in Chicago. I go to Chicago and I go to a place called the Southway Hotel, and I was sitting in the lobby waiting all day for Basie to show up. I didn't think about getting a room or anything, I waited in case I was in the wrong place. I was right from Nashville, you know, down south. So I sat there, until about, oh it must have been about 9:00 at night. And in walks Clark Terry. Clark Terry, he looked at me, I see Clark Terry with his big old flugelhorn you know. The big wide shoulders, the overcoat, and these draped pants that they used to wear at that time, and a hat. I looked and I said, now wait a minute. I'm going to get in some other kind of company. And he said, "man get your room. You get a room. We don't know when Basie'll show up." I said, "I thought we were going to start work." And he said, "no, no, we'll wait for Basie." So I go and get a room. I think we waited about three days before Basie showed up. Basie showed up, and he came in boy looking like he'd been partying for days.

MR: Is this when Basie had the small group?

JL: Yes, the small group. We had Wardell Gray, Clark Terry, Gus Johnson on drums, Freddie Green on guitar, me on bass and like we used Bud DeFranco playing tenor.

MR: Can I read something that Joe Williams said about that group?

JL: Okay.

MR: He says, "I worked with them at the Brass Rail when he had Clark Terry, Wardell Gray, Buddy DeFranco, and in the rhythm section Freddie Green, Jimmy Lewis and Gus Johnson. Talk about swinging? They'd get into some things that would swing you into bad health."

JL: Yeah, at that time I was fast on the bass you know. And I had a different sound from most of the guys, because I never learned to put the strings where they're really supposed to be. But being around Ray Brown and Oscar Pettiford, all these guys, they got me out of that. They said, "look, put the strings down." They said, "the bass don't have the sound it's supposed to have. Anyway you don't have to play as hard or anything." So I did it and I got used to it after a few weeks. And Joe Williams used to come in and he was very shy at that time. You know he'd come walking on the bandstand and he used to sing these little love songs you know, just real sweet and then he'd walk off the stand. And I said I wonder why Basie likes him so well. And so I asked Basie one day. I said, "Basie, what do you see in Joe Williams?" He say, "You just wait." He said, "I see something that maybe nobody else sees." But he said, "that man can sing." I said okay. So I stayed with Basie and we worked the Brass Rail down at the Loop. We opened up one night and all the people were sitting at the tables you know, and so Basie started off real soft. We started playing soft you know. I thought I was playing louder than anybody, I mean I'm

just playing it. Basie says, “Don’t play so loud.” He said, “they’ll hear ya.” So I cut down on the bass. And Basie set a tempo and then he’d watch the people’s feet. He said, “Okay, everybody’s starting to feel you over the conversation.” He said, “Now Gus, pick up your sticks.” Gus was playing with brushes. He said, “Pick up your sticks.” He said, “We’ve got ‘em now.” And by the time we opened up, everybody turned you know and looked and you couldn’t believe it. Buddy DeFranco walked out to the stand, and man, everybody would start to play. He and Clark Terry started doing tricks. Clark would take his horn, take the mouthpiece off and just put it in the end of a glass and blow you know, and make all kinds of funny sounds you know. And Gus Johnson, then here comes Wardell Gray. He’d walk up and he’d just play something like Lester Young you know. And we started playing anything he had. Neal Hefti was making arrangements for the band. And Neal wrote all these beautiful things. And we’d make the thing sound like a 16 piece band. And Freddie Green boy, he was like a metronome sitting there. And you couldn’t get away from him. The tempo might move up a little bit, I’d get excited, and Freddie would say, “come back here. Right here.” And boy that thing would take off. And Basie, he’d sit there and give signs. He had all kinds of signs. He’d do his face, you know when he’d want you to play louder or softer you know. And when he’d get ready to close a number he’d double his fists you know. And like if he wanted some excitement, he’d stand up from the piano and look at you you know. And boy, and Gus was sitting on the drums and you’d hear this thing, it sounded like it was coming up out of the floor. And boy the people just went crazy. We went there for two weeks. And they kept us six weeks in there. And after we left there, we went to another club called the Capitol Lounge. And we went there for two weeks. By that time we had added another horn. We had Marshall Royal. Marshall Royal came in the band and when we went to the Capitol Lounge, man, whew, people just couldn’t believe it, you know. People would stand there and look and they would applaud for the same tune over and over. And we’d play and play and play, the man would say, Basie’d say, “Well I guess our two weeks are up here.” And the man said, “No,” he said, “You’ve got eight more weeks here.” The man at the theater gave us ten weeks. And then we went out to California to a place called the Oasis. And we went in the Oasis and the same thing happened there, you know, just over and over. And then we got a call from one of these agents that said we had to do a movie with Sugar Chile Robinson, he was a little piano player, looked like he was a little midget. And so he went and did the movie, and we did the movie out there on the lot. I think until around 4:30 or 5:00 in the morning. But we’d get paid for that time, being there. Bing Crosby, he’d come through in his car you know. And Frank Sinatra, we went out to his house, went out to Esther Williams’ house. She had it all set up for all that swimming stuff. I think she must have made a picture back there. And we went to Rochester’s

house, you know he had an open house. He never closed his doors. People were sitting all around the pool, with ice buckets and food, and anything you wanted to do. He hardly was there.

MR: The success of that group — what do you think it was attributed to? Just because you had such a great rhythm?

JL: Well, Basie, see he knew how to select guys that would fit together. And then after he'd get the guys he'd talk to them. He'd say, "Look, this is what I want—this is the way I want you to sound." He said, "You know to sound like Basie you have to play this way." And he'd tell them what he'd want. And somebody would come and bring an arrangement, and he'd take the arrangement and listen to it. He'd say, "All right now, I want to take that section out of the trumpet there, that eight bar, and leave that open for me." And he'd say "Now I want you to do this and I want you to use your hats in certain places, and your plungers, and the trumpets I want you to just shake the notes in certain place." And then you'd say, "okay." And we'd get up and we'd do it. He said, "Now that sounds like Basie." Boy that was something.

[Pause]

MR: This is great. I know you've got so much stuff.

JL: I've got so much stuff that I haven't even gotten to yet.

MR: Well, keep going.

[Pause]

MR: Are we rolling, Tim? Well we were talking about the small Basie group. Did it get to the point where Basie wanted the whole band back again?

JL: Yes. Are you ready now? One night, see Freddie Green, he didn't join the group right away, the small group. But one night he said, "I need Freddie, I've got to have him." He said, "he's like my left hand." So he got Freddie, then he said, "I'm going to have to have a big band man, I'm so used to the sound, I've got to get the band back. So he got a lot of guys together, and we got the band together and had a rehearsal down to, I think we had this at Club DeLisa. In the daytime we used to go down there, there was nobody there. And the band sounded pretty good. Let's see who'd we have in that band? Oh, well you know it changed three times. What he would do he'd get all these guys and we'd play and he'd listen. And you could tell if he wasn't satisfied, he used to keep his head down you know. Then he'd give everybody notice, everybody in the band, and he'd give notice. He'd say he was going to break up the band. All right he'd break up the band, and then he'd come around our rooms at night. That's just me and you. That's just me and Clark Terry. That's just me and Gus. That's sure just me and Freddie Green. He said, "now don't worry, I'm going to get another band together." He got another one and that one was better. So then he got a third band together. He'd do the same thing. He got another

band. Now all these guys, when they got together it sounded like they'd been playing for years together. So he said, "this is what I want, I can do something with this." So we had a rehearsal. Let's see, Nat Pierce brought some arrangements down, Nat Pierce from Boston. And Neal Hefti brought some, and somebody else brought some and put them down in front of him. Clark Terry and Wardell Grey used to pick up the music like this and never seen it before, and sing it, just like they were reading it with the horns, then put it down and play it. So I look at these guys, and I wondered if I could take this, you know it was difficult. And so he said, "No, don't worry about it." He said, "I'm going to feature you." He said, "I never featured a bass before but I'm going to feature you." I said, "when?" He said, "wait until we get this movie called 'Conversations.'" I don't know if you saw it or not. And through the whole movie, they couldn't think of a tune, but he told me he said "What do you want to do? Do what you want to do and we'll follow you." So I said, "Well I've got a tune I'd like to do." He said, "okay, we'll call it 'Conversations.' So you play as if you're asking a question, and then Clark Terry will come up and take a solo, and then you answer him with your bass, and then Wardell will come up and Buddy" and like that. And so they named the tune "Conversations." And the thing went over well, man. And for a long time it played. And every once in a while now you see it on T.V. And he said, "It's the first time I've ever featured a bass you know." And then I got out and we went to the Million Dollar Theater. We played the Million Dollar Theater and they had an all-girl band there too came in once and we played, and as we left the theater, I think we went to Las Vegas. A club — a big club out there called the Trochedera or something like that at that time. I don't know what it is now. But anyway, we walked in that club and we had the Norman Miller dancers, we had a girl singer, and I think we had Pearl Bailey's brother, a dancer, and somebody else. But anyway we put on a show. That night we get on the big stage, they put those lights on, and everything looked different. I said, "this must be Hollywood." So it was so beautiful when they put the lights on, and we played everything right down here until the show come on. People dancing all out there, and when it was time for the show to come on, Basie said, "all right that's it, 'One O'Clock Jump.'" We did "One O'Clock Jump," man, everybody knew it, people would recognize it, they started applauding. We played that then the man announced the show and the show came on. We played that show, and when we got through, people just kept applauding. They wouldn't stop. And so he had to play another tune you know. I think the tune — oh I can't think of it now. But anyway we left there and we had to go back to California to the Oasis. And then we left and went on tour, with Billy Eckstine and let's see some-body else. But anyway, Billy Eckstine was a big headline. And oh yeah, George Shearing, Billy Eckstine, and somebody else, there was three different, oh, the Nicholas Brothers.

MR: That's quite a line-up.

JL: Oh man, we get out there, now the Nicholas Brothers didn't have any music. So they [inaudible] bass. So I created a tune to fit every tap that they made on the floor. Oh, man, it was the bass, and doing all that stuff with slides and tumbles and all those things. And so they liked it so well, they wanted to write it up. I can't even remember what it was now. But it fit them just like it was a glove.

MR: That's really interesting how the dance and music are so intertwined.

JL: So every time they'd slide, I'd make a slide on the bass. And they'd flip, when they hit they'd make little thumps, I had all kinds of tricks I could do you know. And the bass players, they are doing that stuff now you know. I was doing it way back then. Because it sounded good to me.

MR: Let me ask you about a little thing. I was glancing at your notes and you had a story about flying with Basie? It sounded kind of interesting.

JL: Yeah, you know we had some Army camps to do. We had to ride in the Army planes, you know the ones with two tails you know, and that big thing in the middle. So we got, one day we got on this thing going to one of the camps, and it was noisy, this thing was so noisy you couldn't hear. Now Billy Eckstine and all those guys were used to riding. But me, I was scared to death. We all had parachutes. Basie had on a parachute over by the door you know. So we were going to Texas, Corpus Christi, Texas. So the plane took off, but before we got there, something happened just before we got ready to land. They couldn't get the landing gear down. So the guy kept punching it in back, there was some long pole they couldn't get it down. So the man said, "we're going to have to circle around and go further, and come back around again." So they went around, and started back to see if we could land, and still couldn't get it open. So one of the guys, the one who was right by the back door here, pulled that big door open. Now we were flying. So I said, "what's this — what are you doing?" The guy said, "well see, we're trying to get a little more air in the plane." I said, "air in the plane!" I said, "man, we don't need no more air." So he said, "well, I'll tell you, we're having a problem with the landing gear." And he said, " you might have to bail out." And Basie looked at me. He said "what do you mean bail out?" And so he asked the pilot, he said, "look, are you going to bail out too?" The pilot said, "no, I've got to stay with the plane." He said, "well I'm going to stay with you," he said, "I'm going on with you." "Because," he said, "if I jump out and I pull this string and the 'chute don't open up," he said, "man, I can't fly — I don't have no wings." Well everybody was laughing. And so Billy teased me, he said, "man" he said, "we're going to crash." — oh baby, I don't know what to do. And I'm running back and forth. It's funny, you know I'd never been in a plane before anyway.

MR: Did they finally—something finally happened because you're here with us.

JL: So we get to Corpus Christi, Texas. Now, so finally we land. Everybody set there about 15 minutes before they got out of the plane. It was quiet — boy you could hear a mouse — quiet you know. So everybody started getting out one by one, taking off the parachute, taking their instruments and go outside. We got outside, and we had to play under some trees. We get out there, and set up under these trees out there, in the hot summertime. Oh, man, it looked like a big field. And people, as far as you could see. And they had all these big speakers about like that. So they set the band stand up, all the band stands, they put the music, you know the fella he'd take care of all that. And so then Basie went up to test the piano to see if it was in tune you know. So then he called us, his band. We got up there and Basie was telling about this trip, how much trouble we had with the plane and all that. So the people settled down you know. They settled down and he said, "Listen, we haven't opened yet." We started playing. As soon as we started playing, all these little scorpions come out of the tree and started falling on the bandstand. And it's falling in the bell of the horn, and the guy'd dump it out and keep playing. I got me some string, tying it all around my pants legs you know, in case they would crawl up my leg. And so when we finished the job, now we've got to take this same plane and go to California. So me and Wendell Cully, we walked out to the plane and looked in, and we see all these parachutes on the seats, and Cully said, "They look like dead people, man." He said, "We can't take this thing again, can we?" I said, "No." So I said well let's go tell Basie we don't think we're going to go on this. So we went and told Basie and he said, "I don't blame you, but," he said, "I've got to stay with the band and so you go ahead and see if you can get a train out, and meet us in California." So we did. We got a train. We got to California three days later. And I think we missed one gig. But we got to the gig and we played and everything. So we asked Basie, "How was the trip?" He said, "Man that was the worst trip I ever had," he said. "Good thing you didn't come, because somebody would have died."

MR: That's great. You know what I'd like to do here, is I know our driver is waiting for you—

MK: Oh, he'll wait as long as he needs to. We just don't want to tire you out after we left you in the lobby for 45 minutes.

MR: He can wait? Okay. Because I thought we could come back.

MK: We can take a break, or we can do more another time, or we can, any number—

MR: Is there something else? I mean you have a million stories, I can tell.

JL: Oh, man, so many, I didn't even put them down, but you know, all the different bands I worked with and how I got to work in bands including Cootie Williams, Duke Ellington, a lot of bands. With Buddy Rich, I did a T.V. show with him, and we did shows with — what's the name, the lady that used to sing [sings] when the moon comes over the mountain? Kate Smith.

MR: Kate Smith.

JL: Yeah we did a show with her. And we did all kinds of things, man. Made a movie with Helen Humes. And then we made another movie with Billie Holiday, that was nice, really nice. And then I did a lot more with just different people when I got back in New York.

MR: You worked with King Curtis?

JL: Yeah. I worked with King Curtis for seven years. Formed a solid band, everything. But then I would go downtown and they'd call me for a record date and all. So I had to start playing the Fender bass. I had a different style from all the guys on the Fender bass — my own creation. But it worked out nice for me. So the first week I went down I think I made about three sessions, and I got seven hundred and something dollars. So I said now wait a minute — there's money in this thing. I wonder if I can keep it going. So then I gave King Curtis my notice. Because he kept calling me you know. And this guy named Ray Burns, he saw me down there. And he says, "Jimmy, I heard you on one of these records down here, you're playing the Fender." I says, "yeah." He said, "well you got a pencil and paper?" I said, "yeah." I kept a little book, you know. He said "I've got 17 dates for you," 17 recording dates. I put that down, and I made those dates, and you know you had to go to the union to pick up your check. I'm standing at the window picking up my check and one of the guys turned over and looked mad, I was picking up so many. And so after that I started — there was this play on Broadway called "Hair." They came along. So there was a guy named Galt McDermott, he had a lot of music that he had been trying to get people to listen to, but he didn't know what to do with it. He told me, "I don't know what to do with this." He said, "I can't think of no bass lines," he said, "I thought of a melody, but I can't think of no lines." I said, "I'll tell you, play it. I'll put some lines to it." So I put some lines to the music and I think he put it on a record called, a company called Kilimanjaro I think he said it was, out of somewhere in Canada. And the thing, he called me two weeks later and he said, "Jimmy." He said, "the thing is selling. People are listening to my music." I said, "Yeah?" He said, "Could you come down to do one more date?" So I went down and when I got there that's when he told me about "Hair." He said, "Will you try to do that?" He said, "they got a lot of music." I said, "well we'll give it a try, I don't know." I went down there and went to the Shakespeare House down on, I forgot, anyway, we got down there and that's where we rehearsed you know. Put the music down. I started, so he had a lot of chords down. So I took it and built bass lines from the chords you know. So I kept doing that and they had about thirty-some tunes. And so I looked at the guys and looked at the actors act out there, and I said now this kind of line would fit what they're doing. You know so I'd look at that and then I put the thing together, and so we had a piano player named Neal Tate. Neal Tate said, "I'm going to write these things down for you." So he wrote a whole book about this thick, of

all my bass lines. So then it comes time to record this Broadway show. So we recorded it. And the thing was a hit.

MR: I guess it was.

JL: Yeah. I think in about two years they sold about 80 million records.

MR: Your stamp was all over that thing.

JL: Oh, yeah, yeah. I spent a lot of time trying to get the sound. Like they had a Zane Paul, and Don Leight. Zane Paul, he played bass clarinet and tenor and alto. Don Leight trumpet. Eddy Williams trumpet. And Neal Tate piano, Idris Muhammed on drums, and Charlie Brown acoustic guitar and let's see who else did we have? Oh, Alan Fontaine, he played guitar, electric guitar. So now what I did, I said now I've got to voice this stuff to make it sound different from anything. Because the show is different from anything you ever heard of. It looked like it wasn't anything. I figured it'd last about two weeks. So we got the thing together and did it. Then the critics came in and they listened, and they watched the show, and they liked it so well, man, doggone it was a hit. All right now. The thing was a hit and we had to already record the music. But I wasn't satisfied with the sound. So I took it and polished it up. So Galt said, "look, I got to do another show," and they said, "you just take care of the music part, you know, and hold the band together." So I changed the whole style of the band. Not really, the music was the same except I updated it a little bit. And the kids went crazy on the floor man, oh, they were so glad to do the show. But they had in the opening of the show where they'd sit there and talk on the floor. And so I said well they need something in this act. So I created a tune called "Happy Feet." And they played it very softly. You've got to really listen to hear it you know, but it was just the rhythm section you know, two guitars, electric bass and piano. We'd play that thing man, and it was almost like a jazz tune in parts you know. So boy we played that thing and the people in the audience, you could see them moving to the music you know. All right, but we never really put it in the show you know. I just wanted to fill it there. And when we got ready to close, this is what got me. We got in there one day, and Michael Butler, he was the guy that had all the money. And I think he said he had three hundred million dollars, and when he came to back the show you know, his father had some money he inherited. And so he was a young guy. He didn't know what to do with it, so he said well I'll do this. He used to give us big parties. We'd ride up and down Fifth Avenue in those double decker things and it was nice. The Four Seasons — we'd go to the Four Seasons and all this. So Michael one night, after about, let's see we was there five years. Four years later, the people said, "well I think the show should go on two-fers" you know what I mean — they had to cut the price, see it wasn't doing so good, that's what they told Michael. The house packed like that. So Michael came in one day and he said, he went to the box office and he said, "I heard the show wasn't doing so

well so I came to see what was happening." So they said, "we don't know nothing about that." They said, "it's been packed every day and night." He said, "okay," so he went up in the big office and talked to some of the people, and told them, "the show is closed as of this minute." So he closed the show out. Man, but four days before he closed it, somebody stole my bass book. All the other books were there, but my bass book was gone. And so I went down to one of the record companies we were doing business with, and I happened to see all these books on the floor piled up, you know all these books. Music, Galt's music. So I said look at this. So I peeked in and I looked at it, and I seen my bass lines there, among all the music you know. So I went back and told Gordon. Gordon didn't know anything about it either you know. But I tried to get some money back. So then that's when we had a little lawyer, he shaked them and found out how much they've sat on. And he told me he said, "you know how much money you've got coming?" I said, "no." He said, "you should have about a quarter of a million dollars." I said, "what!" He said, "it's over eight million in records, two years ago." I said, "oh man." So well you know that's part of business. And so I tried and I couldn't get anything to happen with that. So then "Hair" closed. It closed and I decided I'd form me up a little group, a jazz group called Three Sparks and a Flame. Well she was the flame, and so over there, I had wrote about, oh over a hundred tunes at that time. I've got more now. But we decided we were going to do all our tunes. But we ended up doing a lot of Basie and Duke and all these different arrangements you know. I would arrange all the stuff, and set it to the style I wanted. And we could make a trio sound like an eight piece band. No horns. We could do that. And so we got pretty popular. We started getting all these big jobs you know around town. And they called us, in a place called Cafe Society. It was down on 22nd Street and Broadway I think. And we went down there and stayed there a while, and left there and went to another place on 54th Street. So we went in there for a while. And people liked it, they kept calling us back. So I took the group and so we decided we'd do our own booking. So I learned the business end of it. And we were getting a lot of good gigs you know, all these places way out in the suburbs, some places on Long Island, way out on Long Island. And the big golf clubs and all that. And so we did that for a long time, then I decided to do a video. I did a video but it didn't turn out like I wanted. Now I'm working on a Broadway musical. But it's going to be a different kind of musical from all these other musicals you've seen. It's going to be like a play, it's a love story. It's going to be a play, and I wrote all the music for it, and I'm just kind of putting it together now.

MR: Well you have had a marvelous, amazing career, and it's still going, which we're so glad to hear.

JL: Yeah it seems like I'm going to be all right.

MR: If we come back to New York, will you join us for Part II of your story?

JL: Yeah.

MR: That's great. That's just, you told us some absolutely wonderful things. And on behalf of the college, I'd really like to thank you for your time, and I hope we can get together again, because you're just marvelous.

JL: I appreciate it. Thank you.

MR: Thank you so much.

JL: Okay.